

Common Errors (I)

according to

- 1 ☒ According to my opinion, we should go swimming. [216]
☒ In my opinion, we should go swimming.
 'According to' is used with another person or source of information and is not used with 'opinion'. For example:
☒ According to Mary, the beach is closed.
☒ According to the timetable, there is a bus at 10 a.m.
 2 ☒ According to all these reasons, she decided to change jobs. [216]
☒ For all these reasons, she decided to change jobs.
 'According to' is not used with 'reason'.

accompany

- ☒ I accompanied with my father to the concert. [230]
☒ I accompanied my father to the concert.
 'Accompany' means to 'go with', so another 'with' is not needed.

across

- ☒ I acrossed the road. [128]
☒ I crossed the road.
 The verb is 'to cross' while 'across' is an adverb or preposition, as in:
☒ I went across the road.

actor

- ☒ At the end of the play the actor dies. [?]
☒ At the end of the play the character dies.
 An 'actor' is a real person who acts the part of a 'character' in a play, film or TV show. Likewise in novels:
☒ There were so many actors in the story I couldn't follow it.
☒ There were so many characters in the story I couldn't follow it.

admire

- ☒ I really admire you having six weeks' holiday.
☒ I really envy you having six weeks' holiday.
 To 'admire' is to respect or like the good qualities of a person or thing, while 'envy' is to wish you had the

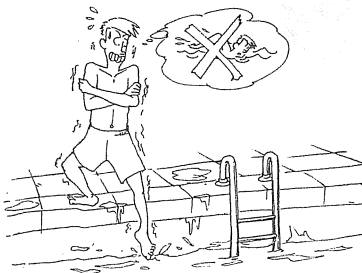
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negative determiner like 'none' should be used with a positive verb.

- 2 ☒ All of them was safe. [193]
☒ All of them were safe.
 'All' takes plural nouns and verbs unless the noun/pronoun is uncountable.

almost

- 1 ☒ He almost swims every day. [108]



- ☒ He swims almost every day.
 If 'almost' is in front of the verb it will modify that verb, meaning he nearly swims but never does. A word like this should be as close as possible to the expression it modifies.
 2 ☒ It was so crowded we almost couldn't move. [343]
☒ It was so crowded we could hardly move.

also

- ☒ I also went there too. [114]
☒ I also went there.
☒ I went there too.
 'Also' and 'too' have the same meaning here and only one of them should be used.

although

- ☒ Although it was raining but we still went on the picnic. [331]
☒ Although it was raining, we still went on the picnic.
☒ It was raining but we still went on the picnic.

good fortune, possessions or qualities of another person.

advance

- ☒ We use a very advance computer in our office. [129]
☒ We use a very advanced computer in our office.
 'Advanced' is the adjective from the verb 'advance'.

advice

- ☒ Her advices are always good. [163]
☒ Her advice is always good.
☒ It was a good advice.
☒ It was good advice.
 'Advice' is, in most senses, uncountable, so cannot be plural or used with 'a'.

afraid

- ☒ I afraid of the dark. [282]
☒ I am afraid of the dark.
☒ Do you afraid of the dark?
☒ Are you afraid of the dark?
 'Afraid' is not a verb but an adjective. The verb is to 'fear'.

agree

- 1 ☒ I am agree; are you agree? [289]
☒ I agree; do you agree?
 'Agree' is a verb, not an adjective.
 2 ☒ I agree Mr Chan; do you agree what he said? [231]
☒ I agree with Mr Chan; do you agree with what he said?
 You agree with a person or idea and you agree to do something.

air-conditioning

- ☒ That tourist bus has no air-condition. [130]
☒ That tourist bus has no air-conditioning.
 An air-conditioner (n) is the machine that makes air cool. This effect is air-conditioning (n) and the building, room or vehicle is described as air-conditioned (adj).

all

- 1 ☒ All of us did not want her to leave. [307]
☒ None of us wanted her to leave.
 A positive determiner like 'all' should not be followed by a negative verb; a

5

In Cantonese, 雖然 and 但係 are used together but in English 'although' and 'but' are never used together like this. It must be one or the other.

always

- 1 ☒ I always listen to the radio. [4]



- ☒ I often listen to the radio.
☒ I listen to the radio every day.
☒ I always listen to the radio in the evenings.
 'Always' means 'at all times', so 'often' or 'frequently' may be more accurate unless the situation is more clearly defined, e.g.:
☒ He always sits at the front of the class.
☒ She always goes to the cinema on Saturdays.
 2 ☒ Taxi drivers always don't know how much they'll earn. [308]
☒ Taxi drivers never know how much they'll earn.
 'Always' should not be used with a negative verb; it should be 'never' with a positive verb.

analysis

- ☒ It is hard to analysis this problem. [159]
☒ It is hard to analyse this problem.
 'Analysis' is the noun; the verb is 'analyse'.

another

- ✗ I don't speak Cantonese and Mandarin. [309]
 ✓ I don't speak Cantonese **or** Mandarin.
 'And' should not join items when the sense is negative.
 ✗ He never swims and runs.
 ✓ He never swims **or** runs.

any

- ✗ I couldn't find what I wanted in the supermarket, so I went to the **another** shop. [178]
 ✓ I couldn't find what I wanted in the supermarket, so I went to **another** shop.
 ✗ She crossed to the **another** side of the road.
 ✓ She crossed to the **other** side of the road.
 'Another' is indefinite, like 'an', so it cannot be used with the definite 'the'. When something is definite, use 'the other'.

any more

- ✗ There is no **any** special method of doing this. [314]
 ✓ There is **no** special method of doing this.
 ✓ There **isn't** **any** special method of doing this.
 'No' is the equivalent of 'not any'.

apply

- ✗ I'm too tired to work **anymore**. [103]
 ✓ I'm too tired to work **any more**.
 'Any more' is always two words.
 ✗ Suddenly a strange person was **appear**. [275]
 ✓ Suddenly a strange person **appeared**.
 'To appear' is a verb that can never be passive.
 ✗ I shall **apply** a job once I get my exam results. [232]
 ✓ I shall **apply for** a job once I get my exam results.
 You **apply to** a person/organisation for a job/membership/scholarship etc.

arrive

- ✗ When she **arrived** my place, we put on our favourite pop music. [232]
 ✓ When she **arrived at** my place, we put on our favourite pop music.
 ✗ When he **arrived** Hong Kong, he was amazed at the changes.
 ✓ When he **arrived in** Hong Kong, he was amazed at the changes.
 One arrives at a particular location (building, park etc) but in a district, city or country. However, no preposition is used with 'home', 'here' or 'there'.
 ✓ When she **arrived home**, her husband had the meal ready.

as

- ✗ As it was quite cold, so he was wearing a sweater. [332]
 ✓ **As** it was quite cold, he was wearing a sweater.
 ✓ It was quite cold, **so** he was wearing a sweater.
 In Cantonese, 因為 and 所以 are used together, but in English 'as/because/since' cannot be used with 'so' like this. It must be one or the other.

at last

- ✗ First I did my Maths homework, then some English and **at last** I studied for the History test. [5]
 ✓ First I did my Maths homework, then some English and **finally** I studied for the History test.
 'At last' should not be used for the final item in a sequence. It does not refer to the order in which things happen. It is wrong to end a speech or letter with:
 ✗ At last, I want to say that . . .
 ✓ **Finally**, I want to say that . . .
 'At last' is used when something happens after a long delay or when something has been eagerly awaited for a long time:
 ✓ Many buses were full and did not stop, then **at last** an empty bus came and we got in.
 ✓ The children had been counting the

avoid

- days, then **at last** Lunar New Year arrived.
 ✗ Jimmy often **avoids** to wash his hair. [273]
 ✓ Jimmy often **avoids washing** his hair.
 The verb 'avoid' is followed by a noun or the '-ing' form of another verb; it doesn't take 'to'.

back

- ✗ After the game, we shall **back** home. [283]
 ✓ After the game, we shall **go back** home.
 'Back' in this sense is not a verb and is in the Cantonese phrase 返屋企 means 'go back' or 'come back'.

barbecue

- ✗ Let's have a **barbeque** on Saturday! [100]
 ✓ Let's have a **barbecue** on Saturday!
 This spelling mistake probably comes from the abbreviations 'Bar-B-Q' and even 'B-B-Q' but the original word has no 'q' - that sound is 'cue'.

because

- 1 ✗ Because she was too young, so she couldn't enter the race. [333]
 ✓ **Because** she was too young, she couldn't enter the race.
 ✓ She was too young, **so** she couldn't enter the race.
 In Cantonese 因為 and 所以 are used together but in English 'because' cannot be used with 'so' like this. It must be one or the other.
 2 ✗ Why did Oliver Twist ask for more? [333]
 ✓ It is **because** he was hungry.
 ✓ He was hungry.
 ✓ He asked for more **because** he was hungry.
 'It is because' seems to be used as a formula for giving short answers to 'Why' questions when a full sentence is required by an exam or test. However, it is not good English and an even shorter sentence is possible by omitting 'because' altogether. Otherwise the main clause of the question must be repeated with 'because' and the answer. Both alternatives are given above.

before

- ✗ She came to Hong Kong ten years **before**. [318]
 ✓ She came to Hong Kong ten years **ago**.
 'Before' is usually followed by something:
 ✓ She came to Hong Kong two years **before I did**.
 ✓ She came to Hong Kong **before 1980**.

behaviour

- ✗ Their **behaviour** are very bad. [172]
 ✓ Their **behaviour** **is** very bad.
 'Behaviour' is uncountable and cannot be plural.
 ✗ Her **behaviours** are always good.
 ✓ Her **behaviour** **is** always good.

better

- ✗ You **better** think about the future. [284]
 ✓ You **had better** think about the future.
 'Better' is not a verb itself, but is used with 'had' followed by an infinitive verb without 'to'.
 ✗ You'd **better** to work hard on this.
 ✓ You'd **better** work hard on this.

between

- ✗ Tomorrow's temperature will vary **between** 28° to 32°. [217]
 ✓ Tomorrow's temperature will vary **between 28° and 32°**.
 ✓ Temperatures will range **from 28° to 32°**.
 One cannot say 'between . . . to . . .'. It must be:
 'between . . . and . . .'
 Or:
 'from . . . to . . .'

- ✗ In a crowded shop you should beware of your wallet. [6]

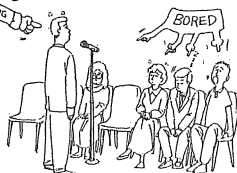


- ✓ In a crowded shop you should take care of your wallet.
 ✓ In a crowded shop you should beware of pickpockets.
 The Cantonese 小心 means being careful, while in English we tell people to 'beware of' dangers and to 'take care of' valuables etc.

bill

- 1 ✗ After the meal, he paid for the bill. [234]
 ✓ After the meal, he paid the bill.
 One 'pays for' goods and services but 'pays' a bill/account/debt etc (i.e. an amount of money required).
 2 ✗ Afterwards, he paid for the meal. [67]
 ✓ Afterwards, he paid the bill.
 ✓ She paid the taxi fare.
 The amount paid for a journey is a 'fare' - on buses, trains, trams, taxis, planes and ships.

- ✗ Listening to the speech, I was very boring. [212]



Listening to the speech, I was very bored.

born

- 1 ✗ I borned in Hong Kong. [276]
 ✓ I was born in Hong Kong.
 'Born' is a passive form of 'to bear', so it cannot have '-ed' added. The adjective/noun form is 'birth':
 ✓ My birthplace is Hong Kong (or place of birth).
 2 ✗ She born a baby last week. [344]
 ✓ She had a baby last week.
 Although the active form is 'bear', this is not often used. 'Have' is used instead.

British

- ✗ He will travel to British on business. [160]
 ✓ He will travel to Britain on business.
 'British' is the adjective; the country is 'Britain'.

broadcast

- ✗ The news was broadcasted at 7.30 p.m. [296]
 ✓ The news was broadcast at 7.30 p.m.
 The simple past tense and past participle of 'to broadcast' are unchanged: 'broadcast'.

brought

- ✗ I went to the shop and brought a new dress. [8]
 ✓ I went to the shop and bought a new dress.
 'Brought' is the simple past tense of 'bring', while 'bought' is the simple past of 'buy'.

built-up

- ✗ The hospital was built up in 1970. [303]
 ✓ The hospital was built in 1970.
 The English verb 'build' does not take 'up' for the construction of a single building, unlike the Cantonese.
 'Up' is added when referring to an area where there are many buildings, usually as an adjective with a hyphen:
 ✓ Shatin is now a built-up area.

busy

- 1 ✗ In the busy time, traffic is very congested. [345]
 ✓ In the rush hours traffic is very congested.
 The Cantonese 繁忙時間 is the equivalent of an English fixed expression, 'rush hour(s)'.
 2 ✗ Because of my busy-work, I couldn't see him. [346]
 ✓ Because I had a lot of work I couldn't see him.
 ✓ Because I was busy I couldn't see him.
 'Busy' describes a person or a period of time, not work.

- 1 ✗ They call him as Tommy. [235]
 ✓ They call him Tommy.
 'Call' does not take 'as'.
 2 ✗ His name is called Tommy. [277]
 ✓ His name is Tommy.
 ✓ He is called Tommy.
 3 ✗ The book's title is called 'Roots'. [278]
 ✓ The book is called 'Roots'.
 ✓ The book's title is 'Roots'.
 'To be called' means 'to have the name/title', so can only be used for people, books, towns etc, not for names or titles.

- 4 ✗ The teacher called all the students to sit down. [7]
 ✓ The teacher told all the students to sit down.
 The Cantonese 叫做 means 'to be called' (as in examples 1-3) but 叫 by itself means 'to tell/order/command'.
 'Call' is only used for an order when it involves people coming towards the speaker, e.g.:
 ✓ Mother called the children to dinner.

camping

- 1 ✗ On holidays we often go to camping. [261]
 ✓ On holidays we often go camping.
 'To' is not used for activities like this. It should be 'go' plus the '-ing' form of the verb, e.g. 'go swimming', 'go roller-skating'.

'Boring' means making people bored. So a film may be 'boring' but cannot be 'bored' - that could only be the people watching.

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 ✓ Shatin is now a built-up area.

- 2 ✗ Next weekend we shall have a camping. [156]
 ✓ Next weekend we shall have a camping trip.
 'Camping' is a noun only in the general sense, so cannot take 'a'. One particular occasion is 'a camping trip' or 'a camping holiday'.

car park

- ✗ There are not many car parks in our building, so we have to pay extra to rent one. [9]
 ✓ There are not many parking spaces in our building, so we have to pay extra to rent one.
 A 'car park' is a large area where many cars can park. A place for one car to park, even in a street, is a 'parking space'.

cement

- ✗ With so many tall buildings, Hong Kong is a cement forest. [347]
 ✓ With so many tall buildings, Hong Kong is a concrete jungle.
 'Concrete jungle' is a set expression for a place with too many buildings close together and not enough greenery.
 'Cement' is the powder which is mixed with sand and water and then hardens to form 'concrete'. A 'jungle' is denser than a 'forest'.

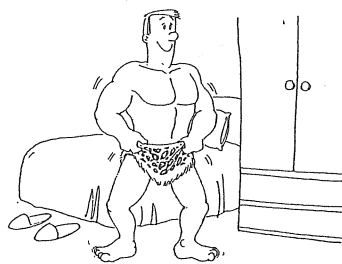
chair

- ✗ I got on the bus and sat in a chair. [10]



cloths

✗ He put on his cloths and went out. [93]



✓ He put on his clothes and went out.
'Cloth' in general is material and 'cloths' are small pieces of material, e.g. for cleaning. 'Clothes' (always plural, with an 'e') are what we wear each day.

✗ His shirt was blue coloured. [115]

✓ His shirt was blue.

✗ She likes red colour.

✓ She likes red.

Although Cantonese repeats 色 after each colour: 藍色, 紅色 etc, 'colour' is not repeated in English.

come back

✗ I'm sorry, the office has only just opened for the morning; Ms Wong hasn't come back yet. [88]

✓ I'm sorry, the office has only just opened for the morning; Ms Wong hasn't come in yet.

In Cantonese, people 返工 or 返學 in the morning. However, in English we 'go/come' to work or school in the morning. We might then 'go/come back' after leaving for lunch or some other reason during the day. The only time we can 'go back' to school or work in the morning is after an absence for holidays, sickness etc.

✓ I got on a bus and sat on a seat.
A 'chair' is moveable (as in a home) while a 'seat' is often fixed, as in a vehicle, theatre etc.

✗ Prices are cheap in a street market. [65]
✓ Prices are low in a street market.
Goods can be 'cheap' or 'expensive' but their prices are 'low' or 'high'.

✗ The China government has new economic policies. [131]
✓ The Chinese government has new economic policies.
The adjective for 'China' is usually 'Chinese'.

✗ I shall choice engineering. [161]
✓ I shall choose engineering.
'Choice' is a noun; the verb is 'choose'.

✗ 5A is a good class; many classmates got over 90%. [61]
✓ 5A is a good class; many students got over 90%.
✓ Many of my classmates in 5A got over 90%.
'Classmate' must be used in relation to someone else in the class: e.g. 'their classmates', 'Mary's classmate'. The Cantonese 同班 is used more widely, when the English would be 'student(s)'.

✗ The shop assistant was talking to a client. [12]

✓ The shop assistant was talking to a customer.

'Client' is used for people seeing lawyers and other professionals as well as in big business, but someone shopping is a 'customer'.

Proofreading: In each of the following questions, there is one or no mistake. For each question, you may underline one word and write another word above it to replace it; or put a ^ between two words and write down an additional word above the ^; or cross out one redundant word. If there is no mistake, put a ✓ on the far right.

1. I am afraid of acrossing that road at night, but I cannot avoid doing so; otherwise, I can't go back home.
2. Although the price of this umbrella is low, I still choose that umbrella because I like red color.
3. Because of the heavy rain, Tom arrived at school late. Jenny was also late too.
4. Scientists are conducting a chemical analysis to analyse a blue substance found on Mars.
5. The father arrived at the hospital at 3:00 p.m. and he waited there anxiously for 5 hours; at last, his baby born at 8:15 p.m.
6. Mother called him to choose the cheap shoes, but he refused. He went back home with the most expensive choice – a pair of Naike costing \$1,200!
7. She feels happy when she arrives school. However, she feels depressed when she arrives home because of her poor relationship with her parents.